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The Ambient Campus: Deploying AI Apps for Academic Operations

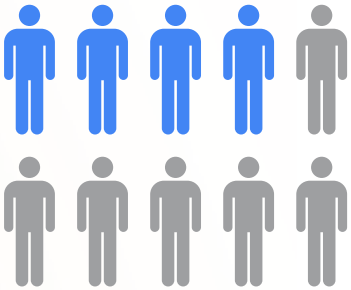


The standard experience in higher education has been defined by a silent, agonizing wait: an admissions staffer spending hundreds of hours reading and then rereading thousands of admissions applications, a transfer student submitting an application who has to wait more than 30 days for a manual transcript evaluation, and a faculty member seeking lab space who finds themself spending three weeks navigating disjointed departmental databases and physical facility audits just to find an empty room.

Across campuses, these workflows aren't merely administrative inconveniences; they are existential threats to tuition revenue and institutional momentum at a time when the sector sits near a financial breaking point. Driven by severe budget cuts, volatile state and federal funding, and demographic declines, campus leadership is trapped in a state of "productive paralysis," as one university administrator shared — hesitant to invest in large-scale changes yet unable to sustain the manual bureaucracy of the past.

40%

of higher-ed leaders are implementing AI to automate routine administrative tasks



Source: 2026 Survey of Campus Chief Technology/ Information Officers. *Inside Higher Ed.*

Into this operational vacuum, AI is emerging as an empathetic partner to higher education teams — serving as a foundational engine that simplifies campus operations while keeping humans in the loop.

While full-time hiring has made small gains in the years since the Covid pandemic, workloads for higher-ed employees remain high. More than half of employees across the sector report regularly working additional hours, according to CUPA-HR's 2025 Employee Retention Survey.

Some departments face even greater pressure. Within IT, 57% of workers are reporting many more additional hours as they respond to growing demands from other departments at their institutions, according to the same CUPA-HR survey. And difficulties in IT hiring haven't eased those workloads, with 67% of campus tech leaders reporting difficulties hiring IT staff, according to *Inside Higher Ed's* most recent survey of chief technology officers.

Driven by hiring freezes and budget-driven vacancies, campus leaders are turning to AI as a vital operational partner. According to the same *IHE* report, 40% of tech leaders are implementing AI to automate routine administrative tasks — a trend reinforced by Tyton Partners' Time for Class 2026 report, which found that 43% of higher-ed administrators now use AI at least weekly. This rapid ground-level adoption is driving top-down institutional commitment: Ellucian's Annual AI industry survey reveals that 43% of institutions have officially integrated AI into their strategic plans, with 60% of higher-ed leaders actively establishing dedicated AI budget allocations to scale these capabilities securely.

This adoption by colleges is directly mitigating employee burnout. "Across institutions, for those remaining people on staff, we're grinding them to the dust," said James Frazee, vice president for information technology and chief information officer at San Diego State University. "If I can get staff to work smarter and not have to work an extra five or ten hours a week … by all means, I want to do that." At San Diego State, staff have found numerous ways to leverage AI to support their day-to-day work. And this sentiment is echoed throughout the California State University system, with staff reporting the highest positive impact of AI of any campus group, at 72%, according to a 2025 system-wide survey of students, faculty, and staff.

At higher-ed institutions across the country, similar sentiments are enabling campus staff to augment their productivity, transforming AI from a tool used in siloed experiments to an ambient partner supporting several departments.



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Streamlining Human Resources, Onboarding, and Internal Knowledge Management

The transition to an ambient campus begins with democratization of institutional knowledge. For many staffers in higher ed, the administrative drag begins on their first day as an employee.

At the University of California at Berkeley IT, the Productivity and Collaboration Services team — led by director, Luis O. Hernández Muñiz — deployed Gemini Notebook to transform the onboarding process. "Previously, there was a whole set of documents that they gave new employees, and that was followed by several days of training and conversations to go through all the material," said Hernández Muñiz.

They've now replaced this labor-intensive onboarding model with secure, queryable AI repositories. New employees are provided with a dedicated, secure notebook pre-loaded with departmental guides, and they can ask natural-language questions like "How do we process departmental billing?" without having to manually parse through hundreds of pages. This shift from manual documentation search to real-time, cited retrieval has significantly accelerated time-to-productivity for new hires at the university.

According to Drew Sidel, North American lead for Google Workspace and AI for Education, other institutions, including Wake Forest University, in Winston-Salem, N.C., and the University of Michigan have all used Gemini Notebook in a similar way, "replacing a dump of a hundred PDFs with a linked notebook that new hires can query directly, in whatever language works best for them," he said.



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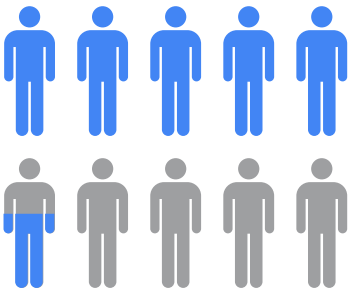
Four hundred miles south, at the University of California, Riverside (UCR), deputy chief information officer Mike Kennedy and his team are using Gemini for complex HR workflows, such as exception-to-hire approvals.

"I had a conversation with HR, where they shared they are experiencing toil having to spend a lot of time approving an exception to hire someone because it's outside of the normal parameters of how we hire someone," said Kennedy. These exception approvals typically require manual coordination loops that stall in email threads between department heads, central HR, and the provost, he said. By developing intelligent agents to parse policies and draft standardized approval packets, UCR has positioned itself to return hours of strategic planning time to academic leaders.

In the 2025 AI survey from Ellucian, 55% of higher-ed administrative leaders reported that using AI to automate operations contributed directly to improved efficiency among their staff. Elsewhere on campus, AI is helping to evolve traditional processes that have stalled institutional growth.

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Source: 2025 Annual AI in Higher Education Survey Report. Ellucian.

Transforming Admissions and Enrollment

The front door of the university represents another high-friction environment where staff are routinely overwhelmed by administrative volume. Across campuses, admissions and enrollment services are deploying the technology to secure institutional pipelines and support a new generation of learners.

At Old Dominion University (ODU), in Norfolk, Va., AI has been implemented to help streamline transfer evaluations and transcript processing. The system uses AI to parse incoming transfer-student transcripts and cross-reference course catalogs, providing those students with immediate course equivalency recommendations. It's one of several uses of AI that the university has built on MonarchMind, ODU's AI-powered platform that's a result of its MonarchSphere partnership with Google Cloud.

While AI has sped up the rate at which transfer students can successfully move through the onboarding pipeline, Chrysoula Malogianni, chief digital experience officer and senior associate vice president for digital innovation at ODU, emphasizes that, ultimately, the new process has been "built with the human in command," she said.

"There's a human in command who's involved throughout the process," said Malogianni. "The human is in command at the beginning, before the AI even translates and maps the incoming transfer student's credits. All the way to the end, where there is a human on staff to make sure that the AI's recommendations are accurate and they reflect the right courses and credits at ODU."

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At UCR, the university has been working with AI to forecast course enrollment demand. "A big challenge on our campus is understanding how many offerings of particular courses need to be put in place ahead of time, and we've been building AI models based on past data to better predict that," said Kennedy. UCR is also working on building a student-facing "Schedule Recommender" powered by Gemini and BigQuery that will allow students to input their degree goals and personal schedules and receive course recommendations based on those factors — with the goal of eventually integrating an agent that, additionally, maps a student's coursework to career opportunities.

The University of Hawaii (UH) is already piloting a similar platform to help match students' academic profiles and objectives with real-world career opportunities with Hawaii. Available to students across UH's campuses, the Hawaii Career Pathways platform uses Vertex AI and BigQuery to analyze massive regional labor market datasets and evaluate each student's qualifications. The tool looks at a student's prior experience, current skills, academic history and credentials, personal interests, and career goals, and guides the student to potential local jobs that could be a good fit.

At ODU, Malogianni said that the university is piloting their own career-pathways tool carefully. "Advisors are using it ... especially when a student realizes midway through a major that it isn't working and they need to see their options. But we want to make sure that we're not removing the human advisor," she said. She advises that when it comes to integrating AI to support the admissions and enrollment functions, it's important to keep the human experience at center. At ODU, AI is not used to replace the time spent interfacing with students; rather, offloading the routine work of course-matching gives their advisors more time to spend mentoring and advising students. "We want to use high tech for high touch — not use high tech to replace high touch," said Malogianni.



Evolving Role of Multi-Agent Systems in Core Administrative Functions

As campus technology frameworks mature, higher ed is moving beyond simple, isolated AI pilots toward interconnected, multi-agent networks. These autonomous agents are designed to collaborate across traditionally siloed Student Information Systems (SIS), Learning Management Systems (LMS), and Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) platforms to execute complex, multi-step administrative workflows under human oversight.

This transition to multi-agent systems, however, requires higher ed to introspect the role of human involvement and responsibility, as Malogianni emphasized. For several colleges, establishing clear boundaries for these autonomous agents is currently a major focus of institutional governance. On a recent virtual forum held by *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, David Weill, the senior vice president for strategic services and initiatives at Ithaca College, in N.Y., discussed how the university organized a presidential working group on AI to undertake a comprehensive audit of 160 different campus policies to evaluate how emerging agentic workflows intersect with academic honesty and intellectual property guidelines. That committee is actively grappling with the core question of accountability in an agentic era, determining who is held responsible when an autonomous agent makes a transaction error or provides incorrect guidance.



Evolving Role of Multi-Agent Systems in Core Administrative Functions

Yet, despite these policy challenges, the operational benefits of multi-agent collaboration are becoming increasingly clear. “While we continue to grapple with the broader implications of artificial intelligence in the academy, the current state of higher ed and the problems we’re facing necessitate some level of innovation … and agentic AI is improving our levels of efficiency across the university,” said one university administrator.

Weill, at Ithaca College, shared how the university is using autonomous agents to constantly monitor student records. When an agent identifies a missing waiver or course requirement, it automatically drafts and sends a comprehensive email alert to the student and their advisor.

UCR is partnering with Google to co-develop Grants AI, an agentic platform designed to accelerate federal research submissions. The agent autonomously scans Google Scholar to identify and match faculty members with grant opportunities tailored specifically to their research profiles. Once relevant grants are identified, the AI agent drafts preliminary proposal sections for the researchers to manually review.



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Meanwhile, at ODU, administrators are using multi-agent networks within course production. Previously, when a professor designed a new course, translating those lectures, syllabi, and modules into Canvas (ODU's LMS) was a grueling, manual process, said Malogianni. It involved instructional designers and technologies to manually adjust layouts, apply templates, and input schedules — a process that regularly dragged on for six weeks to three months. By delegating these repetitive formatting tasks to a network of specialized, collaborating AI agents, that work has now been compressed to less than a day.

These administrative agents act as a modern operational buffer, mirroring the historical evolution of the Learning Management System. When the LMS was first introduced, it was widely praised because it absorbed low-value administrative tasks, such as students repeatedly asking for a lost syllabus, and freeing faculty to focus on actual instruction. In the AI era, multi-agent systems are poised to absorb routine transactional communications, freeing academic advisors and frontline staff from repetitive informational inquiries so they can focus on high-touch, relational student mentorship.



Democratizing Campus Innovation With Low-Code and No-Code Tools

In order for higher-ed institutions to evolve from AI adoption to an ambient campus, where AI plays a quiet role supporting functions across the institution, the role of central IT must shift from a bottlenecked service provider to a strategic enabler of campus-wide creativity.

“We can provide guidance. We can point to resources on how to use it. But we can’t be the only source because it’s used in so many different ways,” said Hernández Muñiz at Berkeley IT.

One way to enable AI transformation across the university community is to make available secure, low-code and no-code tools.

At SDSU, Gemini for Education and Gemini Notebook helped serve as gateway experiences to no-code productivity, allowing them to use natural-language prompts to easily and quickly transform unstructured data. At UCR, Gemini and the tools offered through Google Workspace allow departments from across the university to build their own no-code agents. Outside the U.S., faculty at the University of Malaysia Perlis (UniMAP) are experimenting with various Gems — customizable versions of Gemini that you can set up without any coding — to create things like an on-demand, 24-7 study partner for students.

Critical to these opportunities to engage with no-code and low-code tools is a private, secure environment within which to explore, said UCR’s Kennedy. At Riverside, in addition to the data protection Gemini offers, employees are provided with secure, dedicated Google Cloud Platform project enclaves that allow them to safely experiment with data-informed workflows without exposing protected student records or violating FERPA standards.

By embedding AI integration directly into five-year and ten-year strategic planning processes, universities are moving beyond isolated, grassroots experimentation toward an ambient unified campus ecosystem.



Google

Full-Stack AI for Academia

Google delivers a unified, full-stack AI ecosystem for higher education, combining a complete first-party AI stack with the seamless integration of Google Cloud, Google Workspace, and Gemini for Education. Grounded in over two decades of pioneering research and supercomputing infrastructure, this powerful platform features more than 200 foundation models and over 100 petabytes of public datasets. Built to scale from small colleges to large universities, our flexible solutions empower institutions to personalize learning, diversify pedagogy, accelerate multidisciplinary research breakthroughs, and optimize IT operations within a secure digital campus. Together, we provide the foundation for academia to drive student success, automate operations, and lead innovation in the age of AI.

Take the next step with these AI resources and programs:

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- **Download the 2026 Tambellini StarChart™ Analyst Report to discover why Gemini was named a Commander in AI Agent Platforms.**
- **Sign up for our Google AI Educator Series, a collection of snackable and stackable training from Google and ISTE+ASCD, available to all educators free of charge.**
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